

Small business tax filing checklist guide by entity type with step-by-step instructions — Action Checklist

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IDENTIFY YOUR BUSINESS STRUCTURE

- ☐ **Identify Your Business Structure:** Search your state's Secretary of State website to determine whether you registered a formal business entity such as an LLC or corporation.
- ☐ **Identify Your Business Structure:** Stop the entity search if you never filed formation documents because you operate as a sole proprietor and file Schedule C on your personal 1040.
- ☐ **Identify Your Business Structure:** Count your business owners to determine whether you have a single-member entity or a multi-owner structure that requires different tax treatment.
- ☐ **Identify Your Business Structure:** Write your entity type in one sentence such as "I am a single-member LLC taxed as a sole proprietor" and keep this statement with all your tax documents.

FILE THE CORRECT TAX FORMS

- ☐ **File the Correct Tax Forms:** File Schedule C as part of your personal 1040 if you are a sole proprietor or single-member LLC because your business income flows directly to your individual tax return.
- ☐ **File the Correct Tax Forms:** Submit Form 1065 if you have a multi-member LLC that has not elected S-corp status because partnerships report income at the entity level before distributing to owners.
- ☐ **File the Correct Tax Forms:** Complete Form 1120-S if you elected S-corp status for your LLC or corporation because S-corps file a separate return but income passes through to shareholders via Schedule K-1s.
- ☐ **File the Correct Tax Forms:** Issue Schedule K-1s to each partner or shareholder after filing Form 1065 or Form 1120-S because every owner must report their share of business income on their personal 1040.

COMPLETE YOUR TAX SUBMISSION

- ☐ **Complete Your Tax Submission:** Pay yourself a reasonable salary before taking distributions if you own an S-corp and actively work in the business because the IRS requires salary as a precondition for distribution treatment.
 - ☐ **Complete Your Tax Submission:** Consult a CPA for detailed guidance if you operate as a C-corporation because corporations file Form 1120 and face double taxation on dividends paid to shareholders.
 - ☐ **Complete Your Tax Submission:** Place specific numbers in the correct IRS boxes on each form because the agency does not accept spreadsheets and requires income and expenses reported in designated fields.
 - ☐ **Complete Your Tax Submission:** Sign and submit every form in your stack after reviewing each line entry because the IRS holds you responsible for accurate filing regardless of whether you used an accountant.
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